stopgap arrangements to save lives. Any and all preventive measures which needed to be taken would have to be taken immediately assuming that this infection would reach our doorstep sooner or later. Dr Mishra has been one of the key players in the drafting of the National Disaster Management Act of 2005, following his and the then chief minister Modi's experiences reviving Gujarat post the earthquake. As fate would have it, he would once again be in a similar position; primarily advising the prime minister as he steers the country through the pandemic and resurrects the economy.

Minister of Health and Family Welfare, Dr Harsh Vardhan and the secretary of the MoHFW were looped in and advised to set up a surveillance and response system. This system would be responsible for keeping a close watch on how other countries were responding, and learn from their disease monitoring and response systems to therefore adopt best practices.



On 8 January 2020, the secretary of Health and Family Welfare convened the first meeting of the Joint Monitoring Group under the chairmanship of the Director General of Health Services with stakeholders from related departments and the WHO. This meeting was the starting point in reviewing the preparedness of the public health systems and core capacities: those which were in existence and those that needed to be built for timely detection and management of nCoV.[14]

Meanwhile, outside of India, things were progressing swiftly. On the same day, *The Wall Street Journal* published a story about the Chinese state media having reported that the results from preliminary studies showed that the unidentified pneumonia making people sick 'is believed to be a new type of coronavirus'.[15] On 10 January, China published online the genome sequence of the new virus, opening the possibility for scientists around the world to begin research and development work on possible treatments and vaccines.[16]

On 13 January, the first COVID-19 case outside of China was detected in Thailand in an infected traveller from Wuhan.[17]

By 17 January, in India, the MoHFW in coordination with the Ministry of Civil Aviation began thermal screening of passengers from Wuhan at major airports. In-flight announcements and travel advisories for passengers